

BREAK INTO AEROSPACE

UK Space Agency

Engineering & Programme Interview Preparation Guide

Targeted for the 2025–2026 Recruitment Cycle

Critical institutional context for 2025–2026: In August 2025, the UK Government announced that UKSA would cease to exist as an independent executive agency and would be merged with DSIT's Space Directorate in April 2026, retaining the UKSA name and brand while being staffed by experts from both organisations. This is not background noise — it is the defining institutional context for everyone applying to UKSA in 2025–2026.

*UKSA is structurally different from every other organisation in this series in one fundamental respect: **it is a government body, not an engineering organisation.** UKSA does not build spacecraft, develop propulsion systems, or write flight software. Its staff are UK Civil Servants — scientists, engineers, commercial experts, project managers, and policy officials who catalyse investment to advance space-based technology, deliver missions and capabilities that responsibly meet national needs, and champion the power of space. The engineering at UKSA is primarily programme oversight engineering — managing contracts with ESA, industry, and academia — rather than design and build engineering. Engineers who want to design spacecraft should look at RAL Space, Airbus Defence & Space UK, SSTL, or the dozens of UK space companies at Harwell; engineers who want to manage the UK's space investment portfolio, shape national space strategy, and represent the UK at ESA programme boards are in the right place at UKSA.*

PART I · WHAT UKSA ACTUALLY LOOKS FOR

By Seniority Level

- **Intern / UKSA Skills for Space Placement** — UKSA's Skills for Space internship programme places students in host organisations across the UK space sector — not necessarily at UKSA itself — for eight-week paid placements. The application requires three extended questions (maximum 250 words each) answered with reference to the SpaceCRAFT Competency Framework, covering motivation, relevant skills, and interest in the UK space sector. The selection process is blind-screened centrally by UKSA before candidates are matched to host organisations — different from most other companies in this series, where individual companies recruit their own interns directly.

For roles within UKSA itself, recruitment is through Civil Service Jobs. UKSA offers a limited number of internships in policy, strategy, and communications — highly competitive placements providing unique insight into the workings of a government agency in the space sector. These placements primarily attract policy-track candidates rather than engineering practitioners.

- **Mid-Level (HEO / SEO / Grade 7 equivalent, ~3–10 years)** — UKSA is a civil service employer operating under the Civil Service Success Profiles framework, which assesses five areas: Behaviours, Strengths, Experience, Technical knowledge, and Ability. Most Civil Service interviews at every grade are heavily focused on Behaviours — assessed using competency-based questions where candidates provide STAR-

structured examples. For mid-level UKSA roles, the Behaviours most commonly assessed are Seeing the Big Picture, Making Effective Decisions, Delivering at Pace, and Collaborating and Partnering. Technical knowledge is assessed against the specific space domain relevant to the role — ESA programme management, Earth observation, space science, launch, or regulation.

The specific context that shapes mid-level UKSA hiring in 2025–2026: UKSA is implementing the UK Space Industrial Plan (published March 2024 by DSIT and the MOD), managing the National Space Strategy, and navigating its own absorption into DSIT while maintaining operational continuity. Staff joining now are entering an organisation in genuine institutional transition — which creates both opportunity and uncertainty.

- **Senior (Grade 6 / Grade 7 / SCS, Policy Lead / Programme Director)** — At senior level, UKSA looks for civil servants who can carry significant programme financial responsibility, represent the UK in ESA Programme Boards or international bilateral negotiations, lead multi-stakeholder policy initiatives, and navigate the UK government machinery including HM Treasury, the Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office, and the Department for Business and Trade. The specific senior UKSA differentiator — distinct from senior roles at industry employers — is the ability to operate at the intersection of technical credibility and government policy process: explaining why a specific ESA programme delivers value against the National Space Strategy objectives, in language that lands with both the space science community and with HM Treasury officials, simultaneously.

Hands-On Signal Areas

Domain	Core Competencies Expected
Civil Service Process Knowledge	Knowledge of how UK government works — parliamentary accountability, HM Treasury approval processes, Green Book business case standards, ministerial correspondence, public spending frameworks. Civil servants moving within government bring institutional knowledge that external candidates must demonstrate awareness of.
ESA Programme Knowledge	UKSA manages UK subscriptions to ESA and represents the UK in all space negotiations. Understanding ESA structure, Programme Board decision-making, juste retour for UK industrial return, and how ESA's science, Earth observation, navigation, and telecommunications programmes are governed is the operational context for much of UKSA's programme management work.
Space Domain Technical Literacy	UKSA technical staff need to understand spacecraft systems well enough to evaluate proposals, assess programme risks, and engage credibly with industry and ESA counterparts — but do not need to be practising spacecraft engineers. Systems engineering awareness, mission lifecycle understanding, and the ability to read and evaluate a technical business case are more relevant than deep subsystem design.
Grant Management & Commercial Skills	UKSA manages significant grant and contract portfolios funding UK industry and academia. Commercial acumen, grant assessment experience, and familiarity with UK procurement regulations and Innovate UK processes are valued.
International Engagement Experience	The ability to negotiate, represent, and advocate in multilateral settings — ESA Council meetings, bilateral government discussions, UN COPUOS — is a senior differentiator.
Space Regulation Awareness	UKSA engages with the UK Space Industry Act 2018 framework, orbital sustainability policy, and space traffic management. Staff who understand the regulatory landscape — including the Space Industry Act, the Outer Space Act 1986, and the UN space treaties — are well positioned for policy roles.

How UKSA's Interview Format Differs from Every Other Organisation in This Series

- **UKSA recruits through Civil Service Jobs using the Civil Service Success Profiles framework — not through a company HR portal or a bespoke technical assessment.** Civil Service interviews are scored against pre-defined Behaviour indicators at the relevant grade level — interviewers mark answers directly against these areas using a structured scoring rubric. The process is standardised, transparent, and legally constrained by civil service equality requirements in a way that private sector hiring is not.
- **The job description tells you exactly how you will be assessed — if you read it correctly.** Every UKSA job advertisement on Civil Service Jobs lists the specific Success Profile elements being assessed and names the specific Behaviours that will be tested. Candidates who prepare STAR answers for the specific named Behaviours and ignore the rest are optimising correctly. Candidates who prepare generic space knowledge and ignore the Behaviour framework are not.
- **STAR-structured answers are the primary selection instrument.** Behaviours are assessed through STAR-formatted answers at each grade level, with specific performance indicators that define what “good” looks like at HEO versus Grade 7 versus Grade 6. The indicators are published on GOV.UK.

- **The institutional transition context is live and must be addressed professionally.** UKSA is being merged with DSIT's Space Directorate in April 2026. Candidates who are unaware of this, or who have not thought about what this transition means for the role they are joining, are demonstrating insufficient situational awareness for a civil service role. Interviewers who have lived through the announcement are specifically watching for candidates who engage with the institutional context honestly.
- **Strengths-based questions are used alongside Behaviours at some grades.** Strengths reflect what candidates naturally find energising and are good at, rather than demonstrated past behaviours. The interviewer may ask “what energises you most about this kind of work?” or “when do you feel most effective?” — these require honest self-knowledge rather than prepared examples.
- **Security clearance requirements vary by role.** Most UKSA roles require Baseline Personnel Security Standard (BPSS) checks. Some roles involving classified space programmes may require SC. Roles within the merged DSIT/UKSA that interface with classified national security space work may require higher levels. The job advertisement will specify.

Honest caveat on format variation: UKSA operates primarily from Harwell Science and Innovation Campus (Oxfordshire) and London offices. The technical culture, programme focus, and interview depth differ by team — an Earth observation programme manager role will have a very different technical flavour from a space regulation policy role or a launch programme manager role. Within the post-merger DSIT Space Directorate, additional variability from legacy DSIT staff and processes will affect culture during the transition period. Read each specific job advertisement with care.

PART II · 20 SPECIFIC PREPARATION TASKS

Intern / Early Career

1. Study the Civil Service Success Profiles Framework — Understand All Five Elements and How They Are Assessed 3–4 h

Skill: The selection framework that governs every UKSA/Civil Service interview

Objective: The Success Profiles framework replaced the old Civil Service Competency Framework and is now used across all government recruitment. It assesses Behaviours, Strengths, Experience, Technical knowledge, and Ability — and interviewers mark answers directly against the Behaviour indicators at the relevant grade. Candidates who arrive at a UKSA civil service interview without knowing the Success Profiles framework are equivalent to candidates arriving at a BAE Systems assessment centre without knowing what STAR stands for — they are missing the structural foundation of the selection event.

Done Signal: You can name all nine Civil Service Behaviours (Seeing the Big Picture, Changing and Improving, Making Effective Decisions, Leading and Communicating, Collaborating and Partnering, Building Capability for All, Achieving Commercial Outcomes, Delivering at Pace, Managing a Quality Service), explain what each means, and describe the difference between how each is assessed at EO versus HEO versus Grade 7 level. You have found and read the published Behaviour indicators for your target grade on GOV.UK.

2. Prepare the Three SpaceCRAFT Competency Application Answers — for the Skills for Space Internship Programme 3–4 h

Skill: Written application quality for UKSA's managed internship matching process

Objective: The Skills for Space application requires three extended questions (maximum 250 words each) answered with reference to the SpaceCRAFT Competency Framework — covering motivation, relevant skills, and interest in the UK space sector. All applications are blind-screened by UKSA before matching. The blind screening means your answers must stand alone without the benefit of name recognition, institutional affiliation, or recruiter relationship. The 250-word limit is a hard constraint that rewards concise, structured writing.

3–4 h

Done Signal: You have written three answers — each exactly within the 250-word limit — that specifically reference SpaceCRAFT competencies by name, connect your academic background to concrete skills relevant to a space host organisation, and demonstrate genuine knowledge of the UK space sector beyond the most famous missions. A peer outside your institution has read each answer and confirmed the motivation feels genuine, not generic.

3. Understand What UKSA Does — and What It Does *Not* Do — and Why This Distinction Matters for Your Application

2 h

Skill: Institutional literacy that prevents the most common UKSA applicant mistake

Objective: The most common mistake in UKSA applications is treating it as a spacecraft engineering employer rather than a government programme management and policy body. UKSA's staff catalyse investment, deliver missions through funding and programme management, and champion space policy — they do not build spacecraft. An application or interview answer that focuses on spacecraft design, propulsion physics, or satellite systems engineering without connecting it to UKSA's programme management, grant-making, and policy role is demonstrating a fundamental misalignment.

Done Signal: You can explain in two minutes what UKSA does (manages UK ESA subscriptions, funds UK space industry and academia, represents the UK in international space negotiations, supports national space strategy delivery, manages grant programmes) and what it does not do (build spacecraft, operate satellites, conduct mission design). You have a clear, honest answer for why a government programme management role — rather than an industry engineering role — aligns with your interests.

4. Know the UK National Space Strategy and the Space Industrial Plan — at the Level of Their Specific Priorities

3 h

Skill: Policy context literacy for the UK's civil space programme

Objective: The National Space Strategy (September 2021) and the Space Industrial Plan (March 2024) are the defining documents of UKSA's mandate. Every UKSA programme, grant, and initiative can be connected to one of these strategies. Candidates who can name the NSS's pillars and explain what the Space Industrial Plan adds — particularly its joint civil-defence dimension — are demonstrating they have engaged with UKSA's actual mission rather than a generalised enthusiasm for space.

Done Signal: You can name the four pillars of the National Space Strategy (Unlocking Growth, Leveraging Government Demand, Leading and Inspiring, Capturing the Opportunity from Wider Tech Trends), explain what the Space Industrial Plan 2024 introduced that the NSS did not cover (specifically the joint civil-defence dimension and the £15 billion commitment), and name two specific UKSA programmes or initiatives that directly implement one of the strategic priorities. You can do this in under 3 minutes without notes.

5. Understand the UKSA-into-DSIT Merger — What It Means, When It Takes Effect, and What Continuity Is Promised

2 h

Skill: Institutional context engagement that demonstrates situational awareness for a role in a body mid-transition 2 h

Objective: The August 2025 announcement that UKSA would be absorbed into DSIT in April 2026 — while retaining the UKSA name and brand, staffed by experts from both organisations — is the defining institutional event of the 2025–2026 hiring period. Candidates applying for UKSA roles in this period are joining an organisation actively managing a structural transition. An interview panel made up of UKSA civil servants who have lived through the announcement will evaluate whether you have engaged with this context — or are blindly applying to a name without understanding the organisation’s current moment.

Done Signal: You can explain the August 2025 merger announcement accurately (UKSA absorbed into DSIT Space Directorate, April 2026 effective date, UKSA name retained, combined staffing), articulate why the UK government may have made this decision (closer integration of space with broader science and technology policy, streamlining of government space functions), and describe — professionally and without alarm — why you are still motivated to join the merged organisation and what you would contribute.

6. Prepare STAR Answers for the Behaviours Named in the Specific Vacancy You Are Applying For 3–4 h

Skill: Behaviour-specific STAR answer bank matched to the Success Profiles framework

Objective: Every UKSA civil service job advertisement names the specific Behaviours that will be assessed and the grade level at which they will be assessed. Interviewers mark candidates’ answers directly against these Behaviour areas — preparing for Behaviours not listed in the advertisement is wasted effort. The three Behaviours most commonly assessed across UKSA roles are Seeing the Big Picture (connecting your work to broader government objectives), Collaborating and Partnering (working effectively across organisational boundaries), and Delivering at Pace (completing work efficiently under pressure).

Done Signal: You have read the job advertisement for the specific UKSA role you are applying to, identified the Behaviours listed, found the GOV.UK definitions for those Behaviours at your target grade level, and written one STAR answer per Behaviour that demonstrates the specific indicator at that grade. Each answer has been spoken aloud and delivered in under 3 minutes.

Mid-Level (HEO / SEO / Grade 7)

All early career tasks still apply. STAR answers must come from professional contexts. Knowledge of the UKSA/DSIT institutional landscape must be current — this is a fast-changing environment.

7. Study How ESA Is Structured and How UKSA Manages the UK’s ESA Membership 5 h

Skill: ESA programme governance — the operational context for the majority of UKSA programme management roles

Objective: The UK is ESA’s third-largest contributor. UKSA manages the UK’s ESA subscriptions across ESA’s mandatory activities (science, technology, space situational awareness) and optional programmes (Earth observation, navigation, telecommunications, human spaceflight, exploration, launcher). Programme managers at UKSA represent the UK in ESA Programme Boards, advocate for UK industrial return under the juste retour principle, and manage the interface between ESA’s work and UK national policy objectives. Mid-level UKSA staff who do not understand how ESA’s governance structure works — the ESA Council, Programme Boards, ESAC, ESRIN, ESTEC, ESA’s Director General, and the distinction between mandatory and optional programmes — cannot en-

gage credibly in the role they are taking on.

5 h

Done Signal: You can explain ESA's governance structure at a working level — what the ESA Council decides, what Programme Boards govern, what juste retour means and how it is calculated, what the difference is between mandatory and optional ESA programmes, and how UK ESA subscriptions are allocated across ESA's programme areas. You can name three current ESA optional programmes that UKSA contributes to and describe their UK industrial return.

8. Prepare a Story Demonstrating You Have Managed a Complex Multi-Stakeholder Programme — Including Difficult Stakeholders

2 h

Skill: Stakeholder management at the complexity level UKSA's programme environment requires

Objective: UKSA programme managers simultaneously manage relationships with ESA, UK industry (prime contractors and SMEs), UK research councils, Innovate UK, the MOD, foreign governments, HM Treasury, and DSIT ministers and officials. The stakeholder environment is genuinely more complex than most private sector programme management roles. Mid-level UKSA staff who can demonstrate they have managed a programme involving multiple competing interests — and can name a specific difficult stakeholder and what they did — are demonstrating readiness for this environment.

Done Signal: You have a STAR story about managing a multi-stakeholder programme where the stakeholders had genuinely conflicting interests. The story names the stakeholders, the specific conflict, the approach you took to manage it, and the outcome. The story demonstrates that you maintained productive relationships with all parties rather than resolving the conflict by elevating it to your manager.

9. Understand the UK Space Industry Act 2018 and the UK's Space Licensing Regime

3 h

Skill: UK space regulation framework — the legislative basis for UK space activities

Objective: The Space Industry Act 2018 created the UK's domestic licensing framework for space activities — enabling UK-based launch operations, satellite operation licensing, and space activity insurance requirements for the first time. Responsibility for space launch licensing was transferred from UKSA to the Civil Aviation Authority, but UKSA remains engaged in the broader regulatory policy context. Mid-level policy or programme staff who cannot explain what the Space Industry Act covers, who regulates what in the UK space regulatory framework, and what the UK's satellite operator licensing requirements are are missing the legislative context for the UK's commercial space activities.

Done Signal: You can explain what the Space Industry Act 2018 introduced (licensing regime for spaceports, launch, range, and in-orbit operations), what the Outer Space Act 1986 covers (UK satellite operator licensing for entities incorporated or operating from the UK), why responsibility for launch licensing was moved to the CAA, and what the key regulatory challenges of UK commercial launch activities are.

10. Build Working Knowledge of the UK Space Sector's Economic Scale and Skills Challenge

3 h

Skill: Sector economic literacy for UKSA's role as the national space agency

Objective: The UK space industry generates nearly £19 billion in annual income. UKSA's mandate includes growing this economic contribution. The Space Sector Skills Survey 2023 found that 80% of organisations that had recruited faced recruitment difficulties, with systems engineering as the most challenging area — and the skill gap had significantly worsened since 2020. UKSA staff working on economic, skills, or innovation programmes need to understand the sector's economic profile, its

growth ambitions, and its structural talent constraints. Mid-level staff who cannot speak to these dimensions are not equipped for the policy and programme design work they would be doing. 3 h

Done Signal: You can state the UK space sector's approximate annual revenues (£19 billion), employment base, and growth trajectory, explain what the Space Workforce Action Plan addresses and why it was needed, describe the top two skill gaps identified in the 2023 Skills Survey and why they are structurally difficult to close, and explain what UKSA's training programmes fund is designed to do.

11. Prepare a Story Demonstrating Making Effective Decisions Under Uncertainty or with Incomplete Information 1-2 h

Skill: Behaviour-specific evidence for one of UKSA's most frequently assessed Success Profile Behaviours

Objective: Making Effective Decisions is a core civil service Behaviour assessed at every grade. The civil service expectation is that candidates use evidence and sound judgement to make decisions — demonstrating they can weigh options, manage risk, and commit to a course of action even with incomplete information. For UKSA specifically, decisions about which programmes to fund, which ESA options to buy into, or which industry partners to support are made under significant uncertainty — often with insufficient data and competing political pressures. The story must demonstrate that you made a decision rather than escalating indefinitely.

Done Signal: You have a STAR story about a significant decision you made with incomplete or conflicting information — naming the specific uncertainty, the options you considered, the evidence you weighed, the decision you made and why, and what the outcome was. The story demonstrates that you committed to the decision rather than deferring, and that you monitored outcomes and would revise if needed.

12. Prepare a Story Demonstrating Seeing the Big Picture — Connecting Your Work to an Organisation's Wider Objectives 1-2 h

Skill: The Success Profile Behaviour most distinctive to civil service roles — required at every UKSA grade

Objective: Seeing the Big Picture is consistently rated as one of the most important Behaviours for civil service roles and is assessed at every UKSA grade level. The expectation is that candidates understand how their role contributes to broader government objectives — not just to their team's immediate deliverables. For UKSA, this means connecting programme management work to National Space Strategy delivery, connecting grant decisions to UK industrial return targets, or connecting regulatory policy to the UK's international space competitiveness. Mid-level civil servants who cannot make this connection are demonstrating a scope that falls short of what the grade expects.

Done Signal: You have a STAR story where you explicitly connected a specific piece of work you did to a broader organisational or policy objective — naming both the specific task and the broader goal, explaining how you identified the connection, and describing how this awareness changed how you approached the task. The story demonstrates horizontal thinking, not just vertical execution.

13. Understand the UK's Relationship with ESA Post-Brexit — What Changed and What the 2023 UK-ESA Framework Agreement Restored 4 h

Skill: International space policy context — the most significant recent change in UKSA's international relationships

Objective: Brexit created significant uncertainty in the UK-ESA relationship — most consequentially

4 h

removing the UK from the Galileo GNSS programme and creating questions about UK participation in ESA's Earth observation and human spaceflight programmes. The 2023 UK-ESA Framework Agreement re-established the UK's full ESA membership on clarified terms. Mid-level UKSA staff involved in ESA programme management or international policy who cannot explain what Brexit changed, what the 2023 agreement restored, and what the ongoing implications are for UK access to EU space programmes (Galileo, Copernicus) are missing the essential diplomatic context for the work they would be doing.

Done Signal: You can explain what the UK's Brexit-related disruption to its space relationships involved (Galileo removal, Copernicus data access uncertainty, ESA non-EU funding structure), what the 2023 UK-ESA Framework Agreement established, what the current UK status is on Galileo versus Copernicus access, and what the Spaceflight Cooperation Agreement with the US means for UK commercial launch activities.

Senior Level (Grade 6 / Grade 7 / SCS)

All mid-level tasks still apply. ESA knowledge (task 7) must be operational — you should have participated in or directly supported ESA Programme Board meetings or equivalent bilateral negotiations. The Making Effective Decisions story (task 11) must involve a decision with significant financial or strategic consequences.

4–6 h

14. Prepare to Walk Through a Complex Programme You Managed — Including HM Treasury Engagement and Business Case Development

Skill: Senior civil service programme ownership including public spending governance

Objective: Senior UKSA staff manage programmes with significant public expenditure — ESA optional programme subscriptions (each worth tens to hundreds of millions of pounds over a programme cycle), national space programmes (like the £1.6 billion National Space Strategy investment package), and grant portfolios. HM Treasury engagement — including HMT business case approval, spending review bids, and in-year expenditure management — is a daily reality for senior UKSA programme staff. Candidates who have managed programmes with HMT-approved business cases are demonstrating a specific senior civil service capability.

Done Signal: For one programme you personally owned at a senior level, you can answer questions about: the programme objectives and their connection to government strategy, the business case development process (Green Book methodology, options appraisal), the HMT engagement process, the most difficult stakeholder dynamic you managed, and the outcome against original objectives and budget.

4–5 h

15. Prepare to Discuss the UK's Position on Specific Current ESA Programmes — and What the UK Should Do Next

Skill: Senior-level ESA programme strategy — the core of UKSA's international programme management role

Objective: Senior UKSA staff represent the UK in ESA Programme Boards, advocate for UK industrial return, and advise ministers on whether the UK should join or expand its participation in ESA optional programmes. The ability to form and articulate a view — “the UK should expand its contribution to ESA's Earth Observation programme because...” or “the UK should exercise its option to join ESA's HERA mission because...” — requires both technical literacy about what the programme delivers and policy literacy about how it aligns with UK objectives. Candidates who can only describe programmes without having a view about what the UK should do are demonstrating

mid-level analytical scope in a senior role evaluation.

4–5 h

Done Signal: For two current ESA optional programmes you can form a view on the UK's optimal participation level — stating the rationale in terms of both the scientific or technical value and the industrial return and policy alignment. The view is specific enough to defend against a challenge: “you said the UK should increase its Earth Watch contribution, but Copernicus access already covers most of what you described — why is the additional spend justified?”

16. Prepare Specific Examples of Representing an Organisation in International Negotiations or Multilateral Forums

2 h

Skill: International representation at UKSA's senior programme interface

Objective: Senior UKSA staff negotiate with foreign space agencies, represent the UK at ESA ministerial councils, and engage in UN COPUOS (Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space) and other multilateral settings. This requires the ability to advocate for a position, manage trade-offs across alliance relationships, and return home with an outcome that can be defended to ministers and industry. Engineers and programme managers who have only operated in domestic contexts do not have this experience — and it is genuinely difficult to develop quickly without having done it.

Done Signal: You have a story about representing your organisation in a multilateral or bilateral international forum — you can name the setting, the UK (or your organisation's) position, the challenge you faced from another party, how you managed it, and what the outcome was. The story demonstrates that you maintained the relationship while achieving the substantive outcome — not that you won by dominating.

17. Prepare to Discuss the UK's Domestic Launch Ambitions — the Current State of UK Spaceports and What It Means for UKSA Policy

3 h

Skill: UK launch programme awareness — one of UKSA's most visible recent policy challenges

Objective: The UK's ambition to achieve vertical launch capability from UK soil by 2022 was not met — SaxaVord (Shetland) and Sutherland are still working toward first launches, and Spaceport Cornwall's Launcher One attempt in January 2023 failed on its first flight. SaxaVord's spaceport edged toward its first vertical launch licence in 2025. Senior UKSA policy and programme staff involved in launch need to be able to discuss this history honestly — what went well, what the challenges have been, and what the realistic near-term outlook for UK launch is — without either defensively minimising the delays or catastrophising them.

Done Signal: You can give a factual account of the current state of UK vertical launch ambitions (SaxaVord licence progress, Sutherland's status, the January 2023 Launcher One mission failure and its aftermath for Spaceport Cornwall), explain what the regulatory and infrastructure barriers to first UK commercial orbital launch are, and articulate what UKSA's realistic role is in enabling the next attempt at first launch.

18. Prepare a Quantitative Estimation of UK Space Sector Value — and the Policy Levers UKSA Has to Grow It

3–4 h

Skill: Economic reasoning for a government programme management and policy body

Objective: UKSA senior staff are expected to articulate the economic case for UK space investment in terms that land with HM Treasury officials and ministers who are not space specialists. This requires being able to estimate the multiplier effects of space investment, the value of Earth observation data to downstream users, or the revenue generated per pound of public grant — with

order-of-magnitude confidence and honest uncertainty. UKSA staff who can only describe space as “important” without quantifying it are not equipped for the Treasury interface they will regularly face.

3–4 h

Done Signal: You can estimate in plain terms: the approximate GDP contribution of the UK space sector, the approximate leverage ratio of UKSA grant funding (public £ to private £ invested), the approximate value of Earth observation data to UK downstream users such as agriculture, insurance, and emergency management, and one policy lever UKSA has available to grow each metric. You can state uncertainty bounds and name the assumption most likely to shift the estimate significantly.

All Levels

19. Prepare a Specific Answer to “Why UKSA — and Why a Government Role Rather Than an Industry Role?” That Is Honest About the Trade-Offs

2 h

Skill: Institution-specific motivation that survives the most likely follow-up at a government interview

Objective: The “why UKSA” question at a civil service interview is not an HR formality — it is a probe of whether you understand the specific value and specific limitations of a government role. The expected answer engages with what UKSA uniquely enables: the ability to shape the UK’s space strategy rather than respond to it, to represent the UK at ESA and in bilateral negotiations, to allocate public resources across the sector rather than compete within it. Candidates who give an answer that could equally apply to RAL Space, Surrey Satellite Technology, or any other industry employer are not demonstrating the self-knowledge that a civil service interview expects. Critically, the follow-up is often: “And what do you understand about what you give up by choosing a civil service role rather than an industry one?” — this must be answered honestly.

Done Signal: You have a 90-second answer that names one specific UKSA function (ESA programme management, national space strategy delivery, international space diplomacy, or equivalent), explains why this specifically interests you, and honestly acknowledges the trade-offs of a civil service role (compensation compared to industry, pace of delivery, public accountability constraints). The answer demonstrates that you have chosen a government role deliberately, not by default.

20. Verify Right to Work in the UK, Understand the Civil Service Nationality Rules for UKSA Roles, and Review the Baseline Personnel Security Standard Requirements

1–2 h

Skill: Eligibility self-assessment for civil service employment at UKSA/DSIT

Objective: Civil service employment requires right to work in the UK and, for most roles, compliance with civil service nationality requirements — which are more complex than simple work authorisation. Certain civil service roles are restricted to British nationals or Commonwealth citizens; national security-adjacent roles may have additional restrictions. The BPSS check (Baseline Personnel Security Standard) is the minimum standard for all civil service employment and covers identity, employment history, criminal record, nationality, and immigration status. Candidates who arrive at the offer stage without having verified their eligibility for civil service employment have wasted significant recruitment resource.

Done Signal: You understand your right to work in the UK, have checked whether your nationality meets civil service nationality requirements for your target UKSA role, understand what the BPSS check covers, and can answer the relevant eligibility questions clearly and without hesitation. If your role requires SC clearance, you understand what the SC vetting process involves and can identify any personal background factors that may be relevant to disclose.

SUMMARY REFERENCE TABLE

#	Task Description	Target Level	Effort
1	Civil Service Success Profiles — all five elements, grade indicators	All	3–4 h
2	SpaceCRAFT competency application answers — 250 words each	All	3–4 h
3	What UKSA does and does NOT do — institutional clarity	All	2 h
4	National Space Strategy and Space Industrial Plan — specific priorities	All	3 h
5	UKSA-into-DSIT merger — facts, rationale, honest engagement	All	2 h
6	STAR answers for specific Behaviours named in the vacancy	All	3–4 h
7	ESA governance — Council, Programme Boards, juste retour	Mid+	5 h
8	Multi-stakeholder programme management — difficult stakeholders	Mid+	2 h
9	UK Space Industry Act 2018 and licensing framework	Mid+	3 h
10	UK space sector economics and skills challenge	Mid+	3 h
11	Making Effective Decisions story — under uncertainty	Mid+	1–2 h
12	Seeing the Big Picture story — task connected to strategy	Mid+	1–2 h
13	UK-ESA post-Brexit relationship and 2023 Framework Agreement	Mid+	4 h
14	Complex programme walk-through — HMT engagement included	Senior	4–6 h
15	UK ESA programme strategy — current participation view	Senior	4–5 h
16	International negotiation or multilateral forum representation	Senior	2 h
17	UK domestic launch — honest current status discussion	Senior	3 h
18	UK space sector economic reasoning — quantified, with policy levers	Senior	3–4 h
19	“Why UKSA and why government?” — honest about trade-offs	All	2 h
20	Right to work, nationality rules, and BPSS eligibility	All	1–2 h

THE STRUCTURAL REALITY

Every other company in this guide is an engineering organisation. It builds things — rockets, engines, missiles, aircraft, satellites, sensors — and the interview is primarily a test of whether you can contribute to building those things better. UKSA is not. UKSA is the UK government's instrument for shaping the space sector from the outside — by funding, negotiating, regulating, advocating, and strategising rather than by designing, manufacturing, or operating.

This distinction is not a limitation. The ability to direct £1.6 billion of national space investment, to represent the UK in ESA Programme Boards where decisions are made that shape European space science for decades, to negotiate bilateral agreements that open new markets for UK industry, or to design the policy environment in which hundreds of UK space companies operate — none of these functions can be performed from inside a spacecraft manufacturer or a research laboratory. They can only be performed from UKSA, or from the DSIT Space Directorate it is now becoming.

The candidates who succeed at UKSA are those who genuinely find meaning in this specific mode of contribution — who want to shape the system rather than work within it. Those who struggle are those who discover, after joining, that the pace of policy is slower than the pace of engineering, that the constraints of public accountability are more extensive than those of a private organisation, and that the satisfaction of seeing your work fly is replaced by the satisfaction of seeing your strategy adopted — a different kind of reward that requires a different kind of professional patience.

BREAK INTO AEROSPACE
